Ranking Data in Political Science*

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Abstract

A large and growing body of research collects, curates, and analyzes ranking data across diverse scientific domains, enabling the study of preferences over objects ranging from medical treatments to consumer goods. However, existing data resources largely overlook the rich and various ranking data generated in social science research, limiting their visibility and reuse. Here, we present a new database of ranking data compiled from peer-reviewed political science studies. The database standardizes heterogeneous data structures, integrates both fully and partially ranked observations, and encompasses descriptive and experimental designs. It spans a wide range of substantive topics beyond candidate evaluations in preferential elections, including political attitudes, identity, and policy preferences. By consolidating these datasets into a unified and accessible format, this resource enables comparative analysis and supports methodological development for the study of ranked data.

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Background & Summary

Ranking data—data in which each observation is associated with an ordered evaluation of multiple items—are leveraged in scientific inquiry across disciplines [1–3]. Rankings allow researchers to study comparative judgments over a wide range of objects, from medical treatments and consumer goods to political candidates and policy alternatives. To accelerate the analysis of rankings, researchers have made substantial efforts to collect and curate preference data. For example, the statistical literature has drawn on ranking datasets from diverse domains to develop and illustrate methods for analyzing and modeling rankings [4–6]. In parallel, PrefLib provides a widely used repository of ranking and related data for research in recommendation systems, machine learning, and computational social choice [7, 8]. More recently, a vast volume of candidate rankings and their tabulated results have been compiled in the context of American ranked-choice voting elections [9–11]. Some large-scale survey research, such as the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, has also solicited respondents' rankings on parties, leaders, or coalition preferences [12].

While prior research has advanced our understanding of rankings in science, existing data infrastructures seem to largely overlook the rich and diverse ranking data generated within social science research. As we demonstrate in this work, social science applications extend far beyond canonical examples that are available in the above sources [e.g., 5, Appendix A]. Yet the vast majority of these ranking datasets remain fragmented across individual studies, stored in heterogeneous formats, and rarely integrated into reusable repositories, all of which limits the accessibility of these data for social and other scientists. Meanwhile, existing repositories often function as a benchmark library for methodological development. Instead of helping researchers to reanalyze existing data for substantive research, the main focus has been to use the data as illustrative examples or test cases. Consequently, it remains unclear how statistical methods perform in diverse domains and, more generally, what substantive insights ranking data can generate for social science.

In this paper, we introduce a database of *political ranking data* designed to bridge this gap. The database compiles 54 political ranking datasets from 28 original studies published from 2005 to 2025. The primary purpose of the database is to allow social and other scientists to analyze real-world ranking data in political science—beyond stylized examples—and facilitate new discoveries and theory development. Secondarily, our database can also be leveraged to examine when generic statistical and algorithmic methods for rankings fail to analyze a diverse set of political rankings and thus more tailored methods are required. Moreover, applied researchers may also consult with our database when designing new surveys or experiments to obtain political rankings by using the compiled datasets as benchmark examples for power analysis among other tests.

Our database has several unique features. First, we compile data from peer-reviewed political science research. Second, the database standardizes original ranking data, which are stored in vastly different ways, into a unified structure. Third, our database covers a great variation in ranking data, incorporating both fully and partially ranked data, multiple covariates, and descriptive and experimental designs. Fourth, our work spans a wide range of substantive topics beyond candidate evaluation in preferential elections or value orientations. To facilitate the accessibility of these datasets, we also provide a comprehensive code book along with our database, although our standardization allows users to easily differentiate multiple items in the choice set, ranking, the treatment indicator, and other covariates.

We illustrate our database with several selected examples. We also perform multiple validation exercises, including the replication of original findings for the selected examples only using our database. Taken together, our work seeks to establish an infrastructure for cumulative research on ranking data in the social sciences.

Methods

We begin by providing an overview of our methods for compiling our database.

Study and Data Selection

Our goal is to compile a collection of ranking datasets studied in published peer-review articles in political science. To do so, we seek to cover original ranking datasets published in flagship journals in political science. First, we perform a literature review of potentially relevant studies published between 2005 and 2025 in the *American Journal of Political Science*, *American Political Science Review*, *British Journal of Political Science*, *International Organizations*, *Journal of Politics*, and *Political Analysis*. In this initial stage, we identified 56 papers that collect and analyze original ranking data. Next, for each study with ranking data, we identify whether the study is associated with *publicly available* replication data. We primarily searched in data-sharing platforms, such as Harvard Dataverse, and authors' personal websites.

When a single study uses multiple datasets, we compile them as separate data. Similarly, when an experimental or observational study has multiple treatment arms, we compile multiple datasets such that each dataset has two treatment arms (e.g., control and treatment). In our repository, however, we also offer a single file containing all treatment arms for convenience.

While compiling data on political rankings, we exclude any electoral ranking data, such as candidate rankings from preferential electoral systems. For ranking data from actual elections, readers may refer to several existing works [9–11]. We also exclude studies that explicitly mention ranking tasks but contain other types of data, such as compositional data (e.g., percentages of time legislators should spend on different tasks) [13]. In contrast, we keep studies that collect ranking data, while their replication packages contain partial information about the raw ranking data.

Standardizing Data Structure

One of the challenges in compiling databases like ours is that original ranking data are stored in widely different formats. In some studies, ranking data are stored in a wide and ordering format. Namely, each row is a unique unit or ranker, each column is a distinct item, and each cell value represents a marginal rank that a unit assigns to an item. In other studies, ranking data are maintained in a wide and ranking format. That is, each column corresponds to a choice (e.g., first-choice, second-choice, etc) and each cell value is the item that a unit selects for a given choice. Other studies may store the same data in a long format, where multiple rows are used for a single ranker. In some cases, the final "analysis-ready" data are never formally saved and only exist when running replication code.

Moreover, some datasets only report variables that are functions of rankings, such as the dummy variable for whether a given item is in one's top-2 choice. In this case, for each unit, an original ranking needs to be restored. In some cases, we were only able to recover such rankings partially. Another bottleneck is that a group of studies have experimental conditions, while others do not have such conditions. Similarly, the availability and nature of respondent characteristics also differ across studies. Furthermore, while some ranking data are partially ranked data, partial rankings are represented in different ways. In some studies, missing ranks are shown as missing data (e.g., NA and NaN). In others, missing ranks are denoted by "–."

This heterogeneity in ranking data representation suggests that simply making existing ranking datasets accessible to researchers is not sufficient to fully harness the rich information in these studies. Even when analysts wish to provide simple descriptive statistics, the cost of identifying the corresponding code-book and reformatting raw data is not negligible. Additionally, applied researchers may wish to learn from comparing multiple datasets on the same topic. Methodological scholars may wish to test new statistical or algorithmic methods by applying them to a variety of political rankings. In other studies, political scientists may seek to examine people's ranking behavior (e.g., focusing on the number of items and the pattern of partial rankings) by performing meta-analysis of political rankings.

To overcome these practical challenges, our database standardizes raw ranking datasets in a unified format. Table 1 illustrates our standardized structure. All datasets start with a unit identifier (id), followed by a set of available items (A, B, C, and D as examples) and ranking (ranking). For simplicity, we do not put any prefix for the items in the choice set. However, this format allows users to differentiate the items (all variables between id and ranking) from other covariates.

unit	A	B	C	D	ranking	treat	age
1	2	3	1	4	2314	0	45
2	1	3	2	4	1324	0	32
3	NA	1	2	NA	-12-	1	65
⋮	⋮	⋮	⋮	⋮	⋮	⋮	⋮

Table 1: Unified Format for Representing Ranking Data

Each dataset also has a treatment group indicator (treat). For datasets with no (quasi)experimental manipulation, the indicator takes 0 for all units. For political rankings with experimental conditions, the indicator takes 0 for all control units and 1 for all treated units. Finally, any additional variables after the treatment indicator represent covariates (age as an example). When some items remain unranked, we denote the fact by using NA. For the ranking variable, however, we use "–" to represent the missing marginal rank.

We processed about 15 datasets by writing code manually. To scale up the work, we leveraged AI-assisted coding with Claude 3.5 and Claude Opus 4.6. We extensively reviewed and validated the resulting data included in our database (see Technical Validation).

Data Records

This section details the set of ranking datasets included in our database. We first provide an overview of our database and detail several selected datasets regarding their backgrounds, choice sets, and coding of treatment conditions.

Overview

Our database contains a wide range of ranking data. Table 2 shows several features of our database. In total, ours covers 54 ranking datasets from 28 original studies. The table also reports the number of items, whether partial rankings exist, the subfield for each study. Our database offers various ranking data in American politics, comparative politics, international relations, and other subfields of political science. To highlight, most applications are not about candidate rankings in preferential voting, such as ranked-choice voting.

Illustrations with Selected Examples

To illustrate our database, we now provide brief descriptions of ranking data from four selected studies. These political rankings vary in the number of items, substantive topics, the presence of experimental conditions, and the presence of partial rankings. Table 3 summarizes the question and choice set for each study.

1. Fully Ranked Data

Which attributes are more important than others when shaping people's identity in modern politics? The identity dataset offers information about how Americans consider the relative importance of different sources of identity, first analyzed in [3]. The original study obtains data on how people rank four sources of identification, including political party, race and ethnicity, gender, and religion, via a nationally representative sample of American adults. A key question in the study is to what extent partisanship—as a form of social identity—is salient relative to other major sources of identity in American politics. The study examines what it calls *relative partisanship* by asking survey respondents to rank all of the four items.

To address measurement error, the study contains another anchor ranking question for estimating the proportion of random responses in raw data [3]. More specifically, the study asks respondents to rank order four forms of communities from the largest to the smallest in their size—whose correct

Label	# items	Topic	Area	Partial	Study
toxic-group	4	social media	AP		Pradel *et al.* [14]
toxic-intolerant	4	social media	AP		Pradel *et al.* [14]
toxic-threat	4	social media	AP		Pradel *et al.* [14]
toxic-uncivil	4	social media	AP		Pradel *et al.* [14]
deliberation	5	deliberation	AP		Niemeyer *et al.* [15]
police-pattern	7	police	AP		Boudreau *et al.* [16]
police-reform	7	police	AP		Boudreau *et al.* [16]
roadmap	11	election	AP	✓	Boudreau *et al.* [17]
something	3	policy preferences	AP		Egan [18]
identity	4	identity	AP		Atsusaka & Kim [3]
values	7	political values	AP		Jacoby [19]
principles	9	political values	AP		Searing *et al.* [20]
ideology	10	issue importance	AP	✓	Costa [21]
parenting	5	child-rearing values	AP		Bakker *et al.* [22]
education	5	retrospective voting	AP		Flavin & Hartney [23]
issue-human	6	issue importance	AP		Krupnikov & Levine [24]
issue-stats	6	issue importance	AP		Krupnikov & Levine [24]
issue-counts	6	issue importance	AP		Krupnikov & Levine [24]
issue-denom	6	issue importance	AP		Krupnikov & Levine [24]
blame-office	7	accountability	AP		Malhotra & Kuo [25]
blame-party	7	accountability	AP		Malhotra & Kuo [25]
blame-both	7	accountability	AP		Malhotra & Kuo [25]
senate-2022	4	election	AP		Atsusaka [26]
senate-2022-partial	4	election	AP	✓	Atsusaka [26]
house-2022	4	election	AP		Atsusaka [26]
house-2022-partial	4	election	AP	✓	Atsusaka [26]
oakland-2022	10	election	AP		Atsusaka [26]
oakland-2022-partial	10	election	AP	✓	Atsusaka [26]
history-inclusive	4	representation	CP		Haas & Lindstam [27]
history-exclusive	4	representation	CP		Haas & Lindstam [27]
phillipines	4	recognition	CP		McMurry [28]
morality	9	morality	CP	✓	Rathbun & Pomeroy [29]
kashmir-protest	4	identity	CP	✓	Nair & Sambanis [30]
kashmir-economic	4	identity	CP	✓	Nair & Sambanis [30]
kashmir-army	4	identity	CP	✓	Nair & Sambanis [30]
kashmir-map	4	identity	CP	✓	Nair & Sambanis [30]
religion	6	identity	CP	✓	McCauley & Posner [31]
sentiment	7	political traditions	CP	✓	Fielding [32]
goals	3	bureaucracy	CP	✓	Andersen & Moynihan [33]
dispute	7	territorial disputes	CP	✓	Fang & Li [34]
syria-2015	6	civil war	IR	✓	Corstange [35]
syria-2017	6	civil war	IR	✓	Corstange [35]
sectarian	6	civil war	IR	✓	Corstange & York [36]
aid	5	foreign aid	IR	✓	Dietrich [37]
escalation	8	escalation	IR		Lin-Greenberg [38]
indicator	4	global regulation	IR	✓	Doshi *et al.* [39]

Table 2: Political Rankings Covered in Our Database
Note: Our database covers three major subfields of political science: American politics (AP), comparative politics (CP), and international relations (IR). A checkmark indicates that the dataset records partial rather than complete rankings.

Dataset	Question and choice set
identity	*Main question:* "We would like to know how important various things are to your sense of who you are. Please rank the items below, where 1 is the most important and 4 is the least important to your sense of who you are." • Political party • Race/ethnicity • Gender • Religion *Anchor question:* "People are fundamentally social beings, and we belong to many communities. Please rank the geographic units below from the smallest to the largest in terms of community size." • Household • Neighborhood • City/town • State
history	"Participants are asked to rank from 1 to 3 (including themselves) their preference for which group member should be group representative." • Hindu member (themselves) • Hindu member • Muslim member
sectarian	"I'm going to read you a list of some of the groups fighting in the conflict right now. In general, with which one do you sympathize most? How about second-most? And how about third-most?" • Free Syrian Army • Syrian government • Syrian Islamist groups • Foreign Islamist groups • Kurdish groups • Hizballah
issue	"While the information you read earlier focuses on health care, the fact remains that our country faces many different problems and our elected leaders can't deal with all of them at once. Please rank the following issues in terms of how you think that our elected leaders should prioritize them." • Federal budget deficit/federal debt • Unemployment/jobs • Gap between the rich and everyone else • The cost of health care • Immigration/illegal aliens • Ethical/moral, and religious decline

Table 3: Questions and Choice Sets in the Four Illustrative Datasets
Note: The identity dataset includes an anchor ranking question for estimating the proportion of random responses.

answer is known to researchers. Leveraging the anchor question, the original study estimates the average rank of each item while correcting for the bias arising from measurement error.

2. Fully Ranked Data with Experimental Manipulation

How does history affect the way marginalized groups are recognized by and incorporated into politics in a pluralistic society? The history dataset provides information on how Indians rank multiple members of a group as a potential group representative [27]. The original study addresses how the way a nation's history is told affects whether marginalized people feel entitled to become leaders—and whether others accept them as leaders [27]. The study performs an online experiment, where it seeks to study the causal effect of different representations of history (exclusive, inclusive, and netural) on the ranked preference of Hindu Indians over their representatives.

In the experiment, participants were randomly assigned to read one of three textbook-style history passages: (a) inclusive history that portrayed India as pluralist and highlighted the positive contributions of Muslims, (b) exclusive history that portrayed India as fundamentally Hindu and depicted Muslims as foreign invaders and (c) neutral history that mentioned non-political topics like agriculture and railways with no identity groups emphasized. After reading the historical passages, each subject played a group decision-making game with two other participants, with real money at stake. Each group was composed of two Hindu participants and one Muslim member. The study then asked each Hindu member (as a member of the majority group in India) to fully rank each member of the group (including themselves) based on who they would want the most as the leader of their group.

3. Partially Ranked Data

How do civil war narratives shape people's perceptions about war? The sectarian dataset contains rankings of multiple groups associated with the Syrian civil war [36]. Within the context of the Syrian civil war, this study used a framing experiment to analyze how sectarian framing narratives about the civil war affects civilians' understanding about the war. The study was conducted with 2000 Syrian refugees in Lebanon in 2015.

To gauge people's political leaning, the original study asks Syrian respondents to rank order three of six groups, including the Free Syrian Army, Syrian government, Syrian Islamist groups, foreign Islamist groups, Kurdish groups, and Hizballah. Based on how they ranked the six groups, the study classifies each respondent to one of four groups, including the government supporters, Islamist opposition, nationalist opposition, and other, and analyzes their relative prevalence.

4. Partially Ranked Data with Experimental Manipulation

What kind of evidential fact increases the importance of a given issue in politics? The issue dataset offers rankings of multiple issue topics submitted by American survey respondents [24]. The original study is particularly interested in under what conditions people prioritize the cost to health care as the most important topic (they believe) elected leaders should tackle. To elicit their ranked preferences, the study asks survey experimental subjects to rank six topics, including federal budget deficit/federal debt, unemployment/jobs, the gap between the rich and everyone else, the cost of health care, immigration/illegal aliens, and ethical/moral, and religious decline.

The sutdy examines whether people respond differently to unequal access to healthcare if presented the topic using the context of an individualized story, statistics in percent format or raw counts. Participants were randomly assigned to read one of the messages about unequal access to healthcare. Subjects in the control group had to read a message about unequal access to healthcare. The study then focuses on the marginal ranking probability that the cost of healthcare is ranked first and how it varies across different conditions.

Technical Validation

To validate our database, we perform two checks. First, we examine whether each dataset contains a set of proper rankings. Second, we identify if the original finding from a given study can be replicated solely by using our database.

Tests for Proper Rankings

We begin by investigating whether each unit within each dataset is associated with a proper ranking. This technical validation involves six distinct checks. First, we examine whether the same item is ranked only once. Second, we check whether each unit assigns a unique rank to a single item (e.g., each unit should not rank two items first). Third, we validate whether each ranking data can be re-expressed in an alternative fashion where each column is a choice (e.g., first-choice, second-choice, etc) and each entry is the name of an item selected for a given choice. Such a data reformatting is required in ranking data analysis (e.g., some software require users to process their ranking data in either format) and should fail if a dataset contains improper rankings. In this test, we further check if we can properly recover the ranking format by converting the ordering format. Fourth, we also check if all marginal ranks are within their logical range or [1, k], where k is the number of items. Fifth, we validate if our string of the ranking variable can be properly recreated. Sixth, we validate whether all datasets have the identical structure.

Figure 1 shows that most of our datasets passed the six validation tests. During our validation, we identified several data issues and corrected them accordingly. First, the dataset in [28] contained 5 observations that ranked two items fourth. With no informative note in the original study, we excluded the five rankers from the data. Second, several datasets only contain people's first choices, even though the studies originally collected their entire rankings.

Replications

Next, we check whether our standardization did not affect the substantive information available in the original data. For this technical validation, we replicate several key findings or statistics from the four selected studies we discussed above by only using our database. Figure 2 shows the results of our replication.

In the top-left panel, we replicate the key finding from [3, Figure 8]. We report the estimated average ranks of the four sources of identity, gender, race/ethnicity, religion, and party. We leverage their plug-in bias-corrected estimator for correcting measurement error based on random survey responses. We find a clear pattern that adult Americans—in the absence of any priming—, on average, consider gender as the most important category and party as the least defining group. On average, we also find that race/ethnicity and religion are equally relevant for Americans.

In the top-right panel, we turn to the analysis originally conducted by [27, Figure 5]. Here, we visualize the distribution of marginal ranks (in proportion). To recap, each Hindu Indian subject ranks order two Hindu members (including themselves) and one Muslim participant in the same group. It shows that Hindu respondents have differing preferences for their second and third choices, while the difference is not present for their first choice.

In the bottom-left panel, we report our results for the study in [36, p. 445]. As discussed, the original study seeks to understand factional learning in the Syrian civil war by asking Syrian refugees to rank three choices out of six groups. The study then classifies each respondent into one of four groups: government supporters (who rank the government or Kurdish groups first), Islamist oppositions (who rank the FSA first and rank Islamist groups second), nationalist oppositions (who rank

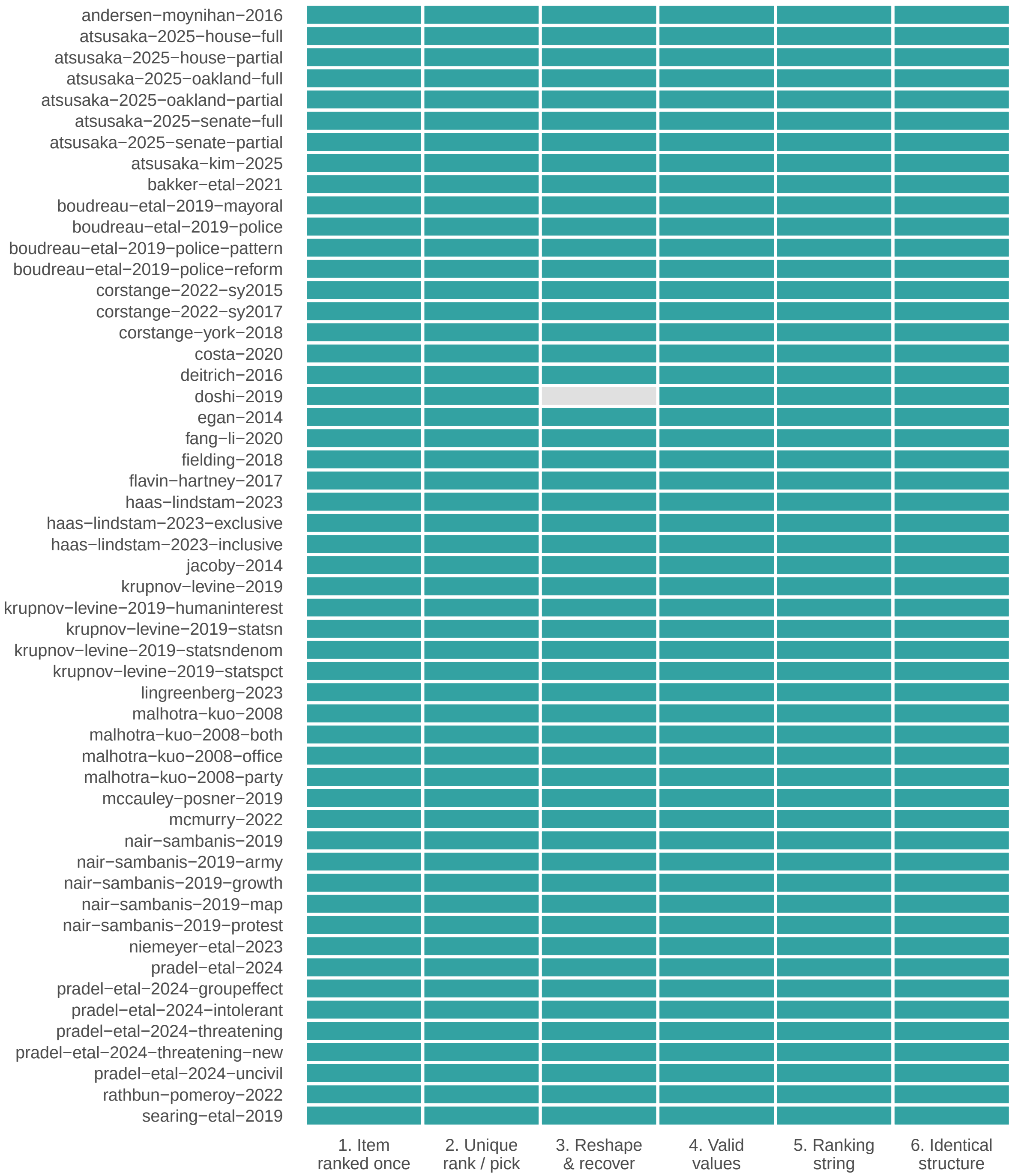

Figure 1: Validation Tests for Proper Rankings

the FSA first and do not rank Islamist groups second), and others.

Finally, in the bottom-right panel, we replicate the original finding by [24, Table 3]. The figure shows the estimated average treatment effect of a given framing on the probability that Americans

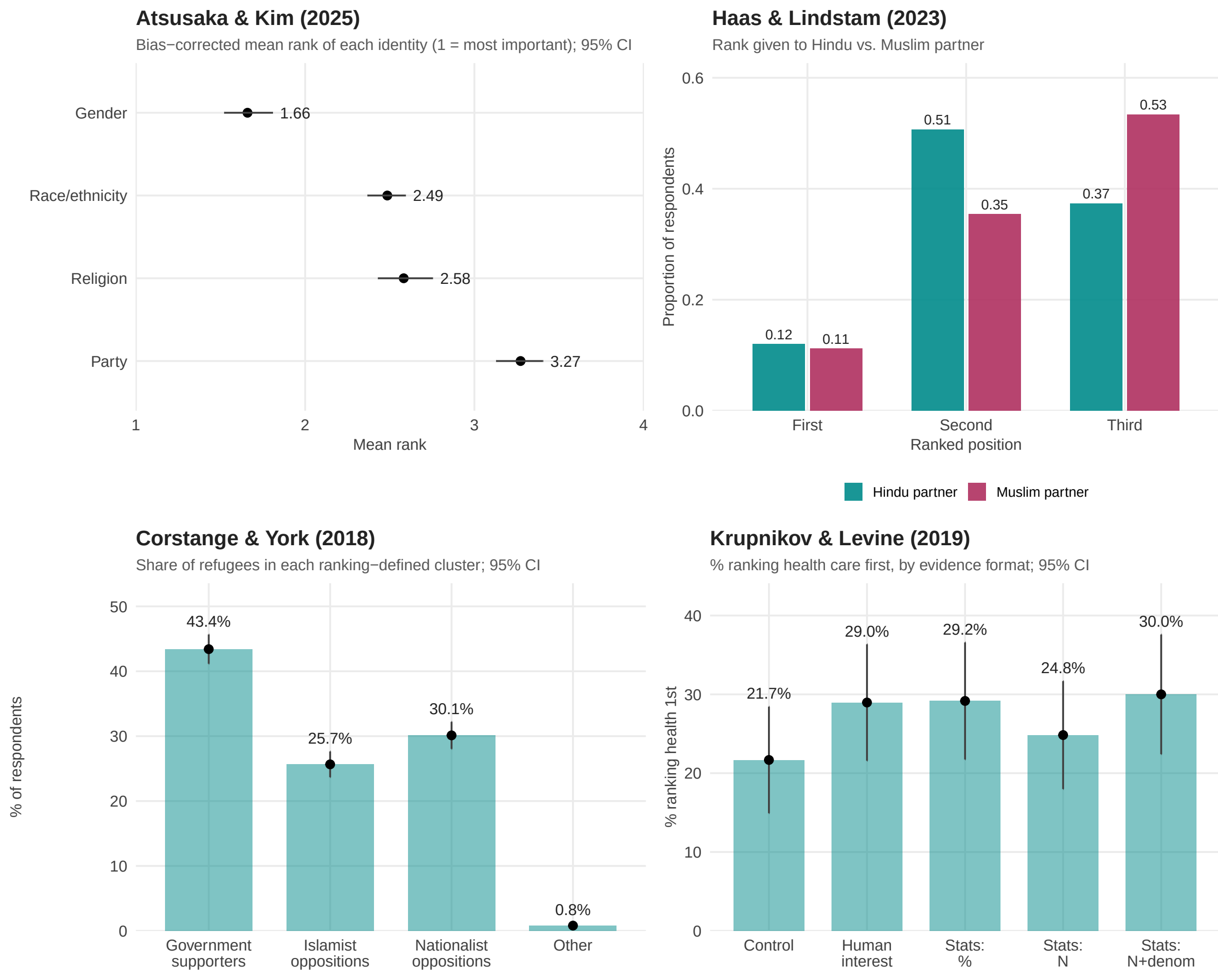

Figure 2: Replicating the Key Findings in the Selected Studies

rank health care as the most important issue out of six issues—the federal budget deficit/federal debt, unemployment/jobs, gap between the rich and everyone else, the cost of health care, immigration/illegal aliens, and ethics/moral and religious decline.

We then compare our results to their original counterparts. Across the four studies, we find that the replication was successful, demonstrating that our database allows us to replicate the original findings. Beyond replication, our database also allows researchers to re-analyze and draw additional insights from the datasets of political rankings.

Data Availability

Our database is available at https://political-rankings.github.io.

Code Availability

All code and raw data for constructing our database are available in our GitHub repository (https://github.com/YukiAtsusaka/rd-ps). The repository provides reproducible scripts and documentation so that users can replicate the database or extend it to new studies. The replication data for this article will be available in our Harvard Dataverse repository.

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Author Contributions

Y.A. conceptualized the study and designed the database. S.S. collected and processed the ranking datasets. Both authors validated the database and contributed to writing and revising the manuscript.

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